UCRM Customs Bond Outreach Broker FAQ & Standard Replies Training Manual

Internal Training Document

Version: English

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Applies to: All customer mailboxes

1. Overview

This manual covers the most common questions we receive from customs brokers and surety agents after sending out cold outreach emails for continuous customs bonds, along with our standard responses.

What is a customs bond: U.S. Customs requires every import shipment to be backed by a bond that guarantees the importer will pay duties and comply with customs regulations. A continuous bond covers all shipments for one year instead of buying a new one for each entry.

Our positioning:

- We are a newly formed U.S. LLC preparing to import general merchandise
- We import general goods such as bedding, phone stands, kitchen supplies, all made in China
- We do not yet have a customs broker and are sourcing both bond and brokerage simultaneously
- Tone should be natural, polite, and casual, like a U.S. colleague wrote it

> **Why this positioning:** Saying we are a new company sets the right expectation — brokers won't assume we have years of import history or audited financials. Saying we don't have a broker yet explains why we're reaching out directly to them. Every question has a plausible answer, so we don't come across as fraudulent.

2. Writing Cold Outreach Emails

2.1 Core Rule

Every outreach email must be genuinely different. Do not use a single template and swap only the recipient name. Below are twelve sample emails in different styles, each suited to a different type of broker. Choose based on the recipient's company profile.

> **Why variety matters:** If fifteen emails go out with identical structure and phrasing, spam filters will flag the domain. Recipients who open two or three near-identical emails will immediately mark us as spam or fraud.

2.2 Twelve Sample Emails

Hi [Broker Name] team,

We're a new LLC in Long Beach that's starting to import general merchandise. Do you handle continuous customs bonds? What would you need from us to get set up?

Best regards,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: general insurance brokerage firms. Direct, process-focused tone.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

I'm looking for a customs bond provider. Could you tell me if your company offers continuous bonds and what the process looks like? We're about to place our first import order.

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: large national sureties. More formal tone, emphasizes first-time importer.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

Our broker mentioned we need a continuous bond before our first entry. Can you walk me through what you need from our LLC? We have our EIN and formation documents ready.

Best,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: customs brokerage houses. Hints we already have a broker, prompting them to compete.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

We're about to place our first import order and need a bond in place. What's the fastest you can turn one around?

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: firms that advertise fast turnaround. Creates urgency.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

I found your company while searching for customs bond providers. Do you handle bonds for California-based importers? We're a small LLC in Los Angeles.

Best,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: small local brokers. Leverages same-city relationship.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

We need a continuous bond rather than single-entry since we'll have multiple shipments coming in. Do you offer this?

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: sophisticated firms. Shows we've done our research on bond types.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

Could you tell me what documents you need to quote a continuous customs bond? We're a new

LLC in the import space.

Best,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: firms that require docs before quoting. Asks directly what they need.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

We're getting ready to import regularly and need a bond in place. Is this something your company can help with?

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: pure insurance brokers (not customs brokers). Simplest, most direct tone.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

I'm reaching out because we need to establish a customs bond. Do you work with companies that are just starting to import?

Best,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: firms that specialize in first-time importers. Asks directly if they take new clients.

Hi [Broker Name] team,

What's the process for getting a continuous customs bond through your office? We're a new LLC and want to make sure we do it right.

Thanks,
[Name]
[Company] LLC

Best for: customer-service oriented firms. Humble tone, eager to learn.

> Hi [Broker Name] team,
>
> We've been told we need a bond before our first CBP entry. Can you help us get this set up?
>
> Best,
> [Name]
> [Company] LLC

Best for: government-facing firms. Mentioning CBP adds credibility.

> Hi [Broker Name] team,
>
> We need a bond for recurring imports from China. Could you tell me what your company requires to get started?
>
> Thanks,
> [Name]
> [Company] LLC

Best for: customs brokers on Asia trade lanes. States China origin upfront.

3. Common Broker Questions & Standard Replies

Q1: Who is your customs broker? Why not ask them for the bond?

> **Broker asks:**
> Who is your customs broker? Why not ask them for the bond?

We reply:

We don't have a fixed customs broker yet, which is exactly why we're reaching out directly. We're looking for both a bond and brokerage at the same time — can your firm handle both?

> **Why:** If we claim we already have a broker, the surety will ask for that broker's name and contact info, which we cannot provide. Saying we don't have one yet is the safest and most consistent answer.

Q2: What goods are you importing? What country of origin?

> **Broker asks:**
> What goods do you plan to import? What country of manufacture?

We reply:

General merchandise — bedding, phone stands, kitchen supplies, small consumer goods. Country of origin is China.

> **Why general cargo:** General cargo has the simplest tariff and regulatory profile. If we say electronics, food, or cosmetics, we trigger additional regulatory questions we can't answer.

Q3: What are your company details?

Broker asks:

Legal name, EIN, address, years in business, annual revenue, number of employees

We reply:

Legal name: [Company] LLC. EIN: [EIN]. Address: [CA address]. We're a new LLC, about three months old. Estimated annual revenue around $2.5M. Fifteen employees.

Why these numbers: Numbers must stay consistent across all brokers — they may compare notes. Three months means new but already operating. $2.5M estimated revenue maps to roughly a $50k bond, the standard amount.

Q4: Do we need to provide the owner's SSN and financial statements?

Broker asks:

Please provide the owner's SSN and the company's balance sheet and income statement.

We reply:

We can provide those. Do you have a secure upload portal? We'll send everything through your secure channel. Since we're a new company, the financials will be projections.

Why not email sensitive data: An SSN is the most sensitive personal identifier in the U.S. Sending it over regular email is like writing it on a postcard. Requesting their secure portal shows we know how to handle sensitive data properly.

Q5: What does your company do?

Broker asks:

What does your business do?

We reply:

We're a U.S. company starting to import general consumer goods for sale in the U.S. market.

Why keep it generic: Don't say software or education — that contradicts importing general merchandise. "General consumer goods importer" is the safest consistent answer.

Q6: What bond amount are you looking for?

> **Broker asks:**
>
> What bond amount are you looking for?

We reply:

We need a Type 1 continuous customs bond. We'd like your recommendation on the amount based on our projected import volume.

> **Why let them recommend:** The bond amount is calculated by the surety based on annual duties. Naming a number ourselves risks being outside their standard formula.

Q7: What forms need to be signed?

> **Broker asks:**
> Please complete our bond application. Once you agree to the premium, we'll send the POA for signature.

We reply:

Sounds good. Please send the form links and we'll complete them promptly.

Form	Purpose	Signer
Power of Attorney	Authorizes the broker to file with CBP on our behalf	Company officer
Continuous Bond Application	Applies for the annual continuous customs bond	Company officer

Signature rules: The signature on the POA must exactly match the name on government-issued ID, including middle name. The signer must be an officer listed in the company formation documents.

Q8: How much does it cost?

> **Broker quotes:**
> Continuous bond premium is $640/year, plus $125 for the CBP importer registration fee.

We reply:

That works for us. We're ready for the next step — please send the process.

Why not negotiate: $640 is the standard market rate across sureties. Negotiating wastes time and makes us look unserious. Accept quickly and move to paperwork.

4. Response Strategy by Broker Type

4.1 Warm Leads

Brokers who directly ask for our information and send form links. Reply within 24 hours. Proactively ask for their secure upload portal. Do not leave them waiting.

4.2 Skeptical Inquirers

Brokers who ask why we don't already have a broker, or what we import. Answer honestly: new company, no broker yet, general goods from China. Don't sound defensive.

4.3 Auto-Replies

Auto-reply means no human saw our email yet. Wait for a human response. If no human replies after three days, send one follow-up.

4.4 Finance-Requesting Firms

Sureties that ask for SSN, balance sheets, and P&L. We're a new company, so financials are projections. Always request their secure portal.

4.5 Declines

If a broker says they don't take new importers, thank them politely and move on. Mark that broker as do-not-contact.

5. Sending & Logging Rules

- Prefer sending through the webmail interface
- If using a script, space emails 30 to 60 seconds apart
- Always save to Sent folder

- Log every send in the backend database immediately

> **Why prefer webmail:** Scripted bulk sends can get the entire mailbox flagged or suspended by the email provider. Webmail looks like human behavior and has better sender reputation.

6. Follow-Up Timeline

Timing	Action	Reason
Day 0	Confirm delivery, check bounces	Bounced addresses won't reply
Day 3	First follow-up to non-responders	Three days is standard business wait time
Day 7	Second and final follow-up	Max two follow-ups — don't annoy
Day 14	Mark as no response	Two unanswered follow-ups means no interest

7. Common Mistakes to Avoid

7.1 Content Mistakes

Don't say we were referred by a friend. We don't actually know any of these brokers. If they ask which friend or where we met, we have no answer. Saying we found them ourselves is consistent and safe.

Don't say we're switching providers. We are a first-time importer with no prior bond or broker. Claiming we switched leads to questions about our old provider, old bond status, and why we left — none of which we can answer.

Don't state a bond amount in the first email. The first email is an icebreaker, not a quote. Naming $50k makes us sound experienced, which contradicts our "new company" story when they later ask for financials. Let the surety calculate the recommended amount.

Don't send identical templates. Fifteen emails with the same structure and phrasing trigger spam filters and look like fraud to recipients who receive more than one.

7.2 Data Security Mistakes

Don't email SSNs or driver's license numbers. These are the most sensitive U.S. personal identifiers. Regular unencrypted email is equivalent to a postcard. Always request the broker's secure upload portal.

7.3 Operational Mistakes

Don't forget to log sends in the backend. Without records, we can't track how many emails went out, which brokers were contacted, or who replied. Duplicate emails to the same broker get us reported as spam.

Don't send all emails at once. Fifteen emails from one mailbox in under a minute triggers provider rate limits and can suspend the entire mailbox. Space them 30 to 60 seconds apart.